MOREH NEVUCHIM

Opening the Gates: Where the Moreh Truly Begins

Given Tuesday 12 May 2026 · Rambam's Introduction Part 4 & Section 1, Ch 1

Sefer: Moreh Nebuchim (The Guide for the Perplexed) — Rambam **Section:** Concluding the Introduction · Beginning Section 1, Chapter 1 **Text:** Sefaria edition (Rabbi Chaim Makbili's modern Hebrew translation from the Arabic)

Tonight's Roadmap

This evening is a major hinge point. We are:

1. **Finishing the seven reasons for contradictions in books** (reasons 4–7)
2. **Hearing the Rambam's examples** of where each reason appears
3. **Reviewing the entire introduction** from start to finish
4. **Beginning Section 1, Chapter 1** — the first words of the Moreh proper, on **Tzelem u'Demut**

PART 1 — The Seven Reasons for Contradictions in Books

Recap of Reasons 1–3 (Last Week)

#	Cause	Example
1	**Compilation without attribution**	The Mishna — multiple rabbis' views, no attribution preserved
2	**The author changed his mind**	Rambam's own Peirush HaMishnayot — manuscripts show his later corrections
3	**One or both statements are allegorical**	"Hashem is a man of war" vs. "God is not a man" — one is metaphor

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Reason 4 — A Hidden Caveat or Qualification

שיש תנאי שאינו מפורש במקומו... אחד מהם אינו מבואר במקומו

Two statements appear contradictory because one or both have an **unstated condition** that distinguishes them.

Example A — Answering a Fool

don't answer a fool — **אל תען כסיל כאיולתו**

answer a fool — **ענה כסיל כאיולתו**

The Gemara's resolution:

when it concerns Torah, you must answer (can't let foolish ideas about Torah pass) — **בדברי תורה**
when it concerns mundane matters, ignore — **במילי דעלמא**

Example B — Marriage

I find a woman more bitter than death (Kohelet) — **ומוצא אני מר ממות את האשה**
who finds a wife finds good (Mishlei) — **מצא אשה מצא טוב**

The Gemara (Yevamot) asks the contradiction. Resolution: **it depends what kind of wife.** The bitter verse refers to a bad spouse; the positive verse refers to a good spouse. The caveat is implicit.

Reason 5 — Pedagogical Imprecision (The Teacher's Necessity)

כלומר אם עניין מסוים עמוק וקשה לתפיסה שיש צורך להזכירו או לקחתו כהנחה לביאור עניין שקל לתופסו

A deep concept must be touched on to explain a simpler concept. But the student isn't ready for the depth. So the teacher introduces the deep concept **superficially and imprecisely** to enable the immediate lesson.

Later, when the deeper concept is the actual topic, the teacher returns and gives the full, precise account. **The two presentations contradict each other** — but the contradiction is intentional pedagogy, not error.

Why the Rambam Will Use This Method

This is one of the **two reasons** the Rambam openly states he will employ in the Moreh. The reader who notices the contradiction is meant to understand: "When he said it the first time, he was simplifying for the sake of the immediate point. Here is the precise version."

Reason 6 — Hidden Contradictions in Conclusions

היות הסתירה סמויה ולא מתבארת אלא אחרי הנחות רבות

The two statements themselves are **fully consistent**. But each, when combined with additional true premises and taken to its logical conclusion, yields **contradictory conclusions**.

This is the **only one of the seven that is a mistake** — the author didn't notice that two of his consistent statements, when developed, would conflict.

דברים כאלה הם חומקים מעיניהם של החכמים מחברי החיבורים

Even great authors miss this. It's a human limitation, not a deliberate technique.

Important Distinction

The Rambam is NOT discussing bad authors who openly contradict themselves. He's discussing **good authors** whose statements are individually consistent but whose downstream logical implications collide.

Reason 7 — Deliberate Contradiction to Conceal Depth

כורח הדיון בדברים עמוקים ביותר שראוי להסתיר חלק מעניינם ולגלות חלק מהם

The deepest and most fascinating reason. When discussing **profound matters**, the author **intentionally contradicts himself** to:

- Hide the full truth from those not ready
- Reveal partial truth to those who are
- Arouse the discerning reader's attention to dig deeper
- Avoid pronouncing a definitive view on something the author wants the reader to work out themselves

The Technique

ראוי שההמון לא ירגיש כלל במקום הסתירה שביניהם

The contradictions must be **framed so the unsophisticated reader doesn't notice them.** Only the profound reader, examining carefully, will discover the inconsistency and understand: *this is intentional — the author is signaling depth here.*

Famous Examples in the Moreh

Topic	The Apparent Contradiction
Eternity of the universe	In some places he accepts it; in others he rejects it. Is he hiding his real view?
The burning bush	Was it a physical bush that burned without being consumed (a real physical event)? Or was the entire scene a vision in Moshe's mind? The Rambam contradicts himself across the book.

Will's Question — Important Clarification: *Is the Rambam fudging when he leaves these issues open?*

The Rambam is **not** evading. He is **deliberately leaving things unresolved** because he wants the profound reader to investigate, examine, and arrive at understanding themselves. Direct statement of his view would be less effective than carefully placed contradictions that guide the reader's exploration.

There's also a real possibility that, on some questions, the Rambam **did not have a single fixed view** and the contradictions reflect a genuinely open question for him.

The Seven Causes — Comprehensive Summary

#	Cause	Nature
1	Compilation of multiple authors	Reasonable — different sources
2	Retraction over time	Reasonable — change of mind
3	One or both statements allegorical	Reasonable — figurative speech
4	Hidden caveat or condition	Reasonable — context-dependent
5	Pedagogical imprecision for teaching	**Intentional technique**
6	Hidden contradictions in downstream conclusions	**Mistake** — the only one
7	Deliberate concealment of depth	**Intentional technique**

PART 2 — Where Each Reason Appears

The Mishna — Reason 1

אשר לסתירות הנמצאות במשנה ובברייתות הריהן לפי סיבה ראשונה

The Mishna's contradictions are due to **reason 1** — different rabbis' views compiled together. Classic Gemara formulation:

קשיא רישא אסיפא — תשובה: רישא רבי פלוני, סיפא רבי פלוני

"The beginning contradicts the end — answer: the beginning follows Rabbi X, the end follows Rabbi Y."

Even Rebbi Yehuda HaNasi himself appears to contradict himself when he sometimes followed one Tanna and elsewhere followed another:

ראה רבי דבריו של פלוני... וראה דבריו של פלוני... סתם מתניתין מני רבי פלוני

The Talmud — Reasons 1 and 2

ואילו הסתירות או החילופים הנמצאים בתלמוד הריהם לפי הסיבה הראשונה והשנייה

Reason 1 in the Talmud

סבר לה כרבי פלוני בכך וכך, וסבר לה כרבי פלוני בכך וכך

"He held like Rabbi X in this matter, and like Rabbi Y in that matter."

תרי אמוראי אליבא דרבי פלוני

"Two Amoraim citing the same rabbi differently" — the original teacher didn't contradict himself, but two of his students remember different versions.

Reason 2 in the Talmud

הדר ביה רב מהיא — *"Rav retracted from this"*

The Gemara explicitly identifies retractions. The Gemara then asks **which version is final**:

מהדורא קמא דרב אשי אמר לן כך וכך, מהדורא בתרא אמר לן כך וכך

"In Rav Ashi's first edition he taught us this; in his second edition he taught us that."

Tanakh — Reasons 3 and 4 (Mostly)

אשר לסתירות... בכל ספרי הנבואה הריהם מחמת הסיבה השביעית והחמישית

Correction: Rabbi Avraham clarifies during the shiur — most contradictions in Tanakh are due to reasons 3 and 4, not 5 and 7.

The Rambam emphasizes that this is **one of the main reasons he wrote this entire introduction.** The seemingly contradictory verses in Tanakh nearly always dissolve when:

- One verse is recognized as allegory (reason 3), or
- A hidden caveat is identified (reason 4)

Classic Pattern — "Three Verses"

כתוב אחד אומר כך, וכתוב אחד אומר כך — יבוא הכתוב השלישי ויכריע ביניהם

Two verses contradict; a third verse resolves the contradiction — by identifying that one is non-literal, or by supplying the missing condition.

Example — Shlomo's Apparent Contradictions on Death

The Gemara in Shabbat 30 has Rabbi Tanchum of Noy challenge Shlomo:

שלמה לא דייך שדבריך סותרים את דברי אביך אלא שדבריך סותרים זה את זה

"Shlomo, it's not enough that your words contradict your father's — they contradict themselves!"

- David: "The dead cannot praise God"
- Shlomo (Kohelet): **ושבח אני את המתים שכבר מתו** — *"I praise the dead who have already died"*
- Shlomo (Kohelet): **כי לכלב חי הוא טוב מן האריה המת** — *"a living dog is better than a dead lion"*

The Gemara resolves these through caveats — different contexts speak to different aspects of death.

Theological Contradictions Are the Rambam's Real Target

רוב עסקם בדברי הנבואה הוא בהקשר של דינים ומוסר... ואילו מטרתנו אינה אלא להעיר הפסוקים שבחיצוניותם סותרים בדברי אמונות

The Chazal mostly resolve verse-contradictions on legal and ethical matters. **The Rambam's task is to resolve them in matters of theology and belief.** That's the Moreh's project.

Does Tanakh Use Reason 7?

אשר לשאלה אם יש בספרי הנביאים סתירות מחמת הסיבה השביעית זהו נושא עיון וחקירה וראוי שלא תקפוץ למסקנה בכך

Whether Tanakh **intentionally** uses contradictions to conceal depth (reason 7) — the Rambam says this is a matter requiring careful investigation. He **doesn't commit** to an answer here. Don't jump to conclusions.

Philosophical Books — Reason 5

אשר לחילופים בספרי הפילוסופים אנשי האמת בהם הם מחמת הסיבה החמישית

Philosophical works inevitably contain reason-5 contradictions because they must introduce basics first and depth later. The Rambam acknowledges this is a universal feature of teaching philosophy.

Midrash and Agadot — Reasons 6 and 7

כיוצא בזה יש במדרשות ואגדות סתירות גדולות מחמת איזה סיבה

Midrash often has **reason 6** (logical-conclusion contradictions): a Midrash uses one parable to make one point, another parable elsewhere makes a different point, and the conclusions don't fit. Hence the Gemara's saying:

אין מקשין באגדה — *"We don't raise contradictions on aggadah"*

The Midrash is using each parable to teach its local lesson; the global coherence isn't the point.

ויש בהם גם סתירות מחמת הסיבה השביעית

Midrash also uses **reason 7** — deliberate contradictions to conceal depth.

The Moreh Itself — Reasons 5 and 7 ONLY

The Rambam's brave self-declaration:

ואילו החילופים שימצאו בחיבור הזה הם מחמת הסיבות החמישית והשביעית

Any contradiction you find in the Moreh is either:

- **Reason 5** — pedagogical imprecision (deep concept introduced lightly first, fully later), or
- **Reason 7** — deliberate concealment of depth (signaling that the careful reader should investigate further)

Crucially, NOT reason 6 — the Rambam does not claim to have made downstream-logical mistakes. He stakes the consistency of his work on this.

דע זאת ועמוד על כך והתבונן בכך תמיד כדי שלא תבוא מחמת המבוכה

"Know this, hold it firmly, and remain attentive to it always — so that you do not become confused."

PART 3 — Comprehensive Recap of the Entire Introduction

Before beginning Chapter 1, the Rambam's introduction can be summarized as:

Why and For Whom

- Written for **Rabbi Yosef**, his student
- Purpose: to explain **multi-meaning terms and imagery in Tanakh**
- Audience: those **trained in both Torah and philosophy** who are perplexed by the apparent tension

What It Will and Will Not Do

- Will not be exhaustive — Ma'aseh Bereishit (physics) and Ma'aseh Merkavah (theology/metaphysics) can only be discussed in **rashei perakim** (chapter headings)
- The lightning analogy — even understanding comes in flashes; conveying it to others is even harder
- Even Bereishit (the simplest beginning) is multi-layered

Order of Study

Science → Philosophy/Theology → Understanding Hashem

This is why Torah begins with Bereishit — the natural world must be understood before the divine.

Why Meshalim

- The candle and the diamond — worthless candle illuminates priceless gems
- Golden apples in silver settings — surface has value, depths have greater value
- Multi-layered meaning protects the deep truths while allowing access at every level

The Two Types of Mashal

- **Type A — every word matters** (Yaakov's ladder, 7 elements)
- **Type B — general concept matters** (the seductress in Mishlei 7, one unified warning)
- The reader must learn which type they're facing

Advice on Reading

1. Read carefully, every term and chapter sequence intentional

2. Oath 1 — don't teach the Rambam's chiddushim to those unready
3. Oath 2 — give the benefit of the doubt, even forced interpretations are better than unjust accusations
4. The book benefits the beginner (somewhat), the wise-and-perplexed (greatly), the confused-and-self-confident (harms)
5. Mission statement: better to help one elevated person than comfort ten thousand ignoramuses

Seven Reasons for Contradictions (Just Completed)

And **the Moreh contains only reasons 5 and 7.**

PART 4 — Beginning Section 1

Structure of the Moreh

The Moreh has **three sections**. There are some shiurim that skip directly to Section 3 (the most practical and accessible). Rabbi Kada is teaching in order — Sections 1, then 2, then 3 — because real understanding requires the full sequence.

Section 1 — Overview (76 Chapters)

The Rambam opens Section 1 with a verse from Yeshayahu:

> *Open the gates and let the righteous nation that keeps faithfulness"* פתחו שערים ויבא גוי צדיק שמר אמנים *".enter*

Two notes from the opening verse:

- **"Open the gates"** — the book gives tools to unlock difficulties, especially in Hebrew language
- **"Righteous nation that keeps faithfulness"** — only for those righteous in character AND belief; not for the doubtful or non-observant

Section 1 as "Negative Theology"

Section 1 is largely about what God is NOT. Before we can understand what God is, we must clear away what He is not.

Chapters	Focus
1–49	**Incorporeality** — refuting any physical conception of God; explaining the anthropomorphic language of Tanakh
50–69 (approx.)	**Negative theology proper** — the attributes of God can only be understood negatively
70–76 (approx.)	**Against the Mutakallimun** — critique of the Islamic theological philosophers

The Core Message of Section 1 (In One Sentence)

Do not accept things just because you've been told them or read them in a text.

The Rambam will spend 76 chapters elaborating this — the Torah verses describing God's "hand" or "eye" cannot mean what their surface suggests. Tradition alone is not enough; you must penetrate to the meaning.

Negative Theology — Preview

When we say in the 13 Attributes of Mercy:

אל רחום וחנון ארך אפים — *"merciful, gracious, slow to anger"*

These are **NOT describing Hashem.** Per the Rambam:

- "Hashem is merciful" really means **"Hashem is not not-merciful"**
- The more positive descriptions we apply to Hashem, paradoxically, the less we may understand Him
- All true descriptions of God must be **negations**

(This is counterintuitive — we will develop it in coming weeks.)

What Section 1 Will Also Address

- Abuse of the Names of Hashem (kameot/amulets, charms)
- The Mutakallimun — Islamic philosophical school

PART 5 — Section 1, Chapter 1: Tzelem u'Demut

The Verse and the Problem

נעשה אדם בצלמנו כדמותנו *".Let us make man in our image, in our likeness"*

This verse is **the source of all anthropomorphic problems** — the strongest scriptural-seeming evidence that God has a physical form.

What People Mistakenly Think

אנשים חשבו שצלם בעברית מורה על תבניתו ומתארו של דבר... דבר זה הביא להגשמה גמורה

People thought *tzelem* means **physical form/structure**. Combined with **"in our image,"** this led them to **complete corporealism** — believing God has a body, face, hand.

The Self-Justifying Logic

וסברו שאם יטו את האמונה הזאת יכחישו את הכתוב

"They thought that if they rejected this belief, they would be denying the verse — and even denying God's existence."

Their logic: "We can't deny the pesukim, so we must believe God has a body."

The "Refined" Version

Some softened the view: yes God has a body, but:

- Bigger than human
- More illuminated, shining
- **Not made of flesh and blood**

זוהי שיא רוממותו של האל לפי סברתם

"This was the peak of God's exalted nature, according to their view."

This is not as crude as the picture of "an old man with a white beard sitting on a throne" — but it's **still corporeal.** Rambam will reject it equally.

Important Precedent — Ibn Daud

This view was articulated even before the Rambam. **Ibn Daud** (author of *Emunah Ramah*, early 1200s, just before the Rambam) wrote that **some Christians had a purer conception of God than many of the Jews he encountered** — because so many Jews insisted on corporealism on the strength of literal pesukim readings.

The Shiur Komah Problem

There is a Hebrew text called **Shiur Komah** that gives precise measurements of God's body — neck, head, beard. For example:

- *"The length of His neck is 13,000 myriads and 800 parasangs..."*
- *"The circumference of His head is 300,000..."*

Who Wrote It?

Authorship is **debated**. Some Geonim quote it approvingly. In Kabbalah tradition, the book is accepted and treated as containing profound mystical meaning.

The Rambam's Position

In Teshuvot HaRambam (Teshuvah 117), Rambam writes:

לא חשבתי מעולם שהוא מחיבורי החכמים. וחלילה להם שזה יהיה מהם. ואינו אלא חיבור אחד הדרשנים היוונים בטולו. וסוף דבר למחוק זה הספר ולכרות זכרו היא מצווה רבה

"I never thought this was a work of the Chachamim. God forbid it should be from them. It is the work of one of the Greek-style drashanim, and it is null. In short — to erase this book and cut off its memory is a great mitzvah."

The Rambam categorically rejects Shiur Komah. The Sefardi tradition follows the Rambam on this.

Why Corporealism Denies the Unity of God

מה שראוי לומר בהפרכת הגשמת האל ובאישוש אחדותו האמיתית שאינה תקפה אלא בביטול הגשמות

Corporealism doesn't just contradict Hashem's nature — **it contradicts the unity of Hashem.**

The Argument

- Anything physical, by definition, has **boundaries and measurements**
- Even if you imagine an infinite-expanding blob constantly growing — at any given moment, it has measurements (those measurements are changing, but they exist)
- Anything with measurements has **limitations**
- Limitations are incompatible with **the absolute unity of God**

No matter how grand and magnificent you make a physical conception of God, it remains limited — and therefore not the true unity of Hashem.

(This will be developed extensively over the next many chapters.)

To Define Tzelem and Demut, First We Need to Define "Toar"

The Rambam's method: before explaining *tzelem* (which describes the spiritual/intellectual image), he first introduces a contrasting word that **does** describe physical form — **toar**.

Toar = Physical Form / Features

הצורה המפורסמת בקרב ההמון... המונח המיוחד בעברית הוא תואר

Throughout Tanakh, **toar** is the word for **physical form, structure, appearance**.

Examples

Yosef

ויהי יוסף יפה תואר ויפה מראה *"Yosef was beautiful of form and beautiful of appearance"*

The verse introducing Potiphar's wife's seduction of Yosef. *Toar* and *mareh* are both physical descriptors:

- **Toar** — specific features (face, eyes, nose)
- **Mareh** — overall appearance, the whole aura

(Rashi and Ibn Ezra discuss the precise difference; for our purposes both are physical.)

Shaul's Question About Shmuel's Spirit

When Shaul HaMelech, distraught and unable to receive prophecy after Shmuel's death, consults the medium at Ein Dor:

מה תארו? ותאמר איש זקן עלה והוא עוטה מעיל

"What is his toar? She said, an elderly man, wrapped in a cloak."

Toar = physical description of how the figure appeared.

Gideon

כתאר בני המלך

"Like the toar of the king's sons" — Gideon was perceived to have the physical bearing of royalty.

Crafting / Forming Objects

יתארהו בשרד ובמחוגה יתארהו

"He forms it with a marker, he shapes it with a compass."

Forming a physical object — the word again describes **physical dimension**.

The Key Statement

המונח הזה אינו חל על האלוה יתעלה כלל חלילה וחס

This term (*toar*) is NEVER applied to Hashem in Tanakh.

Because *toar* means physical form, and Hashem has no physical form, the Torah never uses it of Him. The Rambam has just made his first philological argument: the very vocabulary of Tanakh respects God's incorporeality.

What This Sets Up

By contrast, when we encounter *tzelem* and *demut* applied to humans being created "in God's image," we know:

- The Torah is using **different** words than the ones it uses for physical form
- Therefore, *tzelem u'demut* CANNOT mean physical form
- It must mean **something else** — the Rambam will tell us what next week

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Where We Stop

We have finished the entire introduction and made the opening move of Chapter 1:

- Established that *toar* is the word for physical form in Tanakh
- Noted that *toar* is never used of Hashem
- Setting up the positive definition of *tzelem* and *demut* for next week

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Coming Up Next

- **Quick review of what tzelem u'demut is NOT**
- **The Rambam's positive interpretation:** what *tzelem* and *demut* actually mean — and how the verse "let us make man in our image" should be understood without any corporeal implication
- This launches the **49-chapter project** of dismantling anthropomorphism systematically

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B'Ezrat Hashem

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